



Social Psychology (SOCPSY)

Module 1: What is Social Psychology

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Lesson Notes

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What Is Social Psychology?

Social psychology is the scientific study of how people think about, feel, and behave in social situations, and how other people (real, imagined, or implied) influence us. It sits at the crossroads of psychology, which focuses on the individual, and sociology, which focuses on society. The central question is straightforward: why do people act differently when others are around?

Social psychology is scientific. It is based on research methods such as experiments, surveys, and observation, not only on personal opinion. Classic researchers you will meet again include Kurt Lewin, who stressed that behaviour depends on both the person and the situation; Solomon Asch, known for conformity; Stanley Milgram, known for obedience; and Leon Festinger, known for cognitive dissonance.

Why This Course Matters for Ugandan Students

On a Ugandan campus you constantly face social situations: group coursework, hostel life, class presentations, family expectations, and online groups. Understanding social influence helps you notice peer pressure, read first impressions more carefully, and see why groups sometimes work well and sometimes fail.

The course is also practical for later work in counselling, community programmes, human resources, and research. Clear ideas about attribution, conformity, and attitudes improve how you interpret people and situations in everyday life, not only in the examination room.

Reflect: Name one social situation from your own campus life where other people's presence clearly changed how you behaved. What do you think caused the change?

Core Ideas

Three simple assumptions guide the field. First, context shapes behaviour: the same person acts differently alone and in a crowd. Second, we construct social reality: our interpretation of events matters as much as the events themselves. Third, social influence is powerful: people often underestimate how much others shape their actions.

A familiar local example is behaviour in a crowded Kampala taxi park or university library: without anyone giving an order, people lower their voices, face a certain direction, and follow unspoken rules. Those unwritten rules are social norms, and they are a core topic of social psychology.

Closing

Social psychology gives you a clear language for processes you already experience. Later modules develop the social self, social perception, groups, helping, attraction, attitudes, and conformity.